

INDIA'S FORTUNES **TIED** TO PARIS EXPLOITS

In a change of pace, the women have a **better chance** than their male counterparts in the Paris Olympic qualification.

Amol Karhadkar

amol.k@thehindu.co.in

September 30, 2023, marked a historic moment in the annals of Indian sports and world table tennis. It was the day two girls from interior West Bengal made history in table tennis, triumphing over the Chinese team on their turf during a major continental sports event.

Sutirtha Mukherjee and Ayhika Mukherjee stunned Chen Meng and Wang Yidi, the World No. 2 pair, in the women's doubles quarterfinal of the Hangzhou Asian Games. The win ensured a historic medal — the first all-women medal for Indian table tennis — at the Asian Games.

The victory instilled the belief that even the formidable Chinese team could be defeated on the grandest stage. For Indian table tennis, it reiterated that the two bronze medals in Jakarta in 2018, including the men's team and mixed doubles, were not isolated successes. It showed that Indian paddlers were ready to compete at a higher level, beyond Commonwealth

achievements.

Although recent, this achievement, along with the unpredictable events of 2023, has become a part of history. The upcoming year remains a mystery, at least for now.

Despite securing podium finishes three times in the last two Asian Games, Indian table tennis still faces a challenge when it comes to the Olympics. Olympic qualification relies on making the most of the available spots.

In a change of pace, the women have a better chance than their male counterparts in Olympic qualification. Manika Batra, having taken over the baton from A. Sharath Kamal as India's torchbearer in global table tennis, is the sole confirmed Indian participant for the Paris Olympics.

Ranked 35 at the beginning of the year, Manika achieved the distinction of being the first Indian to win two matches at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021. With a new personal coach in Aman Balgu, she aspires to reach at least the round of 16 in Paris. However, Manika acknowledges that the path ahead won't be without

challenges.

Manika, who gave a tough fight to Wang Yidi before losing the singles quarterfinal 2-4 in Hangzhou, is aiming to break into the top-25 world rankings. She had achieved her career high of No. 31 in November 2023, but now needs to maintain consistency throughout the year to achieve her objective.

The Mukherjees, who had upstaged the World No. 1 Korean pair of Jeon Jihee and Shin Yubin to win a WTT Contender event in Tunis before the Asian Games miracle, will know that the road to Paris is the hardest, considering the doubles event will continue to have only 16 pairs. If they do not seal a place through the Olympic qualification event in March–April, the duo will have to rely on the World Rankings in early May to make the cut. If they make the cut, as they showed in Hangzhou and Tunis, they can definitely stun fancied opponents.

As for the men, the road to Paris will depend primarily on the World Championships in Busan in February.

Ranked No. 16 at the turn of the calendar, should they fail to make it to the round of 16, the men will have